

How to Test a Teaching

A method for weighing any claim against the text

Use this when someone hands you a teaching, a video, a doctrine, or a claim about what Scripture says. It works on anyone. On the loudest voice online. On your favorite teacher. On this ministry. And on you.

Why this matters

The space you are in is loud and crowded. Anyone with a camera can call himself a teacher, and most people test nothing. They accept a claim because the person sounded sure or showed a sign. Scripture asks more of you. You weigh the teaching against the text, not against the teacher's charisma. A true thing from a flawed person is still true. A false thing from a magnetic person is still false. Pull the claim away from the personality and put it under the text, where charisma cannot help it.

Most of us test the teacher and not the teaching. Does he have a following. Is he respected. Is he relatable. Does the presentation make you feel something. None of that tells you whether the claim is true. Set those questions aside and ask only what the text says.

Discernment is a muscle. It grows with use, not with study you never put into practice.

This tool is not for winning arguments. It is for slowing down, fearing G-d, and refusing to be manipulated.

THE METHOD AT A GLANCE

VERIFY Does the source exist. Does it say what they claim. Does it hold in context. Does the original language carry the meaning.

TEST, in order Ten Commandments. Deuteronomy, with Deuteronomy 13. The rest of Torah. The Prophets. The Writings.

ASK at each level Which direction does it pull. Does it add or subtract a command. Is there a second witness.

DECIDE Receive. Set aside. Reject. Hold.

Phase one. Verify the claim

Most people skip this and lose before they start. Before you weigh whether a teaching is true, confirm it is even real.

- 1. Go to the source.** Open it yourself. First, does the source exist and is it quoted from the right place. This space runs on fabricated and misattributed quotes, invented etymologies, a midrash no one can locate, a verse that is not there. Then, does it actually say what they claim. The teaching often dies right here.

2. **Read the context.** Pull back to the surrounding verses and the whole passage. A verse can say one thing alone and the opposite inside its paragraph. Read what comes before and after. See if the claim survives its own context.
3. **Check the original language.** Whole doctrines hang on one mistranslated word. Run Hebrew through a real tool like Pealim or Morfix. If the claim leans on a Greek term, run it through a tool like a Strong's concordance or a Greek lexicon. Ask whether the translation carries the same meaning as the original, or whether the teacher built a tower on a translation error.

If the claim survives all three, it has earned the actual test. If it fails any one of them, you are done.

Phase two. Test the claim

Now you weigh the claim against Scripture, in order. You start at the clearest, most concentrated ground and work down only as far as the claim forces you. Most teachings never survive the first two rungs.

Why this order

You are ranking clarity, not importance. The whole Torah binds. It does not all sit at the same level of clarity. Direct speech leaves almost no room to misread. Wisdom poetry leaves a great deal. So you stand on the clearest word first. A claim that fails there fails fastest, and you never have to defend a clear text with a murky one. You do not need the whole Tanakh memorized to use this. Most claims fail at the first or second rung, where the text is clearest.

The order of authority

1. **The Ten Commandments.** Worship and the identity of G-d get settled here in one move. Israel heard these directly (Makkot 24a). Any teaching that touches who G-d is, or who receives your worship, is decided at this rung.
2. **Deuteronomy, with extra weight on Deuteronomy 13.** Moshe's own explanation of the Torah (Deuteronomy 1:5, Moshe began to explain this Torah), and the densest source of the commands and the tests themselves. This is where you ask the two gate questions below.
3. **The rest of Torah.** The narrative, the case law, the rest of the five books.
4. **The Prophets.** They apply, rebuke, and call Israel back. They never legislate new Torah and never cancel a command. When a prophet seems to, you have misread.
5. **The Writings.** Inspired and authoritative, and the most open to interpretation. Read these in light of everything above. Never build a doctrine on a line of Proverbs that contradicts Sinai.
6. **Everything else.** Talmud, midrash, the commentators. They illuminate and apply. They never override.

Two gate questions

Which direction does it pull. Toward the G-d of Israel and His Torah, or away from them. A sign, a feeling, or a fulfilled prediction does not save a teaching that moves you away (Deuteronomy 13). Direction overrides every wonder.

Does it add or subtract a command. Add nothing, subtract nothing (Deuteronomy 4:2). The obvious failures cancel a command. The sneaky ones add a new binding obligation that contradicts nothing, so it slips past a filter that only watches for what got removed. Watch both directions.

The second witness

A matter is established by two or three witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15). Apply this to the teaching, not to the text. A command G-d stated once stands on its own, because Torah said it. But a new doctrine built on a verse needs corroboration. If the idea has no second witness anywhere in Scripture, you set it aside even when it contradicts nothing. An interpretation with one anchor and no support is not established. It is one person's reading.

The four verdicts

Tell people exactly where their idea landed. These are four different actions, not a thumbs up or down.

Verdict	What it means and what you do
Reject	It contradicts a higher text. If it moves your worship or cancels a command, do not debate it. Leave.
Set aside	It contradicts nothing, but it has no second witness. Do not adopt it. This is not the same as calling it false.
Receive	It coheres with the higher text and it has a second witness. You can take it.
Hold	It is genuinely debated and you cannot resolve it. Sit in the tension. Be whole with G-d and wait.

How it is being sold

The tests above weigh the teaching. These weigh the teacher. The enticer in Scripture works in secret and sells the new, the hidden, the thing they kept from you (Deuteronomy 13). Watch for:

- **Secrecy.** Do not tell the rabbis. Do not tell your old congregation.
- **Urgency.** Decide now. The time is short. You cannot wait to check.
- **Hidden knowledge.** They hid this from you. Only I have the real name, the real calendar, the real Hebrew.
- **Isolation.** The teaching pulls you away from everyone who might check it.

None of these proves a teaching false on its own. Every one of them is a reason to slow down and run the full test.

Key verses

Numbers 12:6-8	Moshe's prophecy is unlike any other. Why the Torah governs the prophets.
Deuteronomy 1:5	Moshe began to explain this Torah. Why you start your testing in Deuteronomy.
Deuteronomy 4:2	Add nothing to the command, take nothing away.
Deuteronomy 13	The false prophet and the enticer. The direction test. The secret pitch.
Deuteronomy 18:13	Be whole, tamim, with HaShem your G-d.
Deuteronomy 18:15-22	A prophet speaks and it does not come to pass. How a false word is exposed.
Deuteronomy 19:15	A matter is established by two or three witnesses.
Isaiah 8:20	To the Torah and the testimony. The prophet's own measuring line.

For deeper study: Makkot 24a (Israel heard the first commands directly from the mouth of the Almighty). Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Yesodei HaTorah ch. 9 (no prophet may add to or cancel a command).

A note on numbering: Some Bibles number Deuteronomy 13 one verse later than Jewish editions. The add-nothing command sits at Deuteronomy 13:1 in Jewish texts and Deuteronomy 12:32 in many Christian Bibles. The false-prophet section follows either way. Deuteronomy 4:2 reads the same in both.

Run it with your group

A worked example from today

A teacher claims that a certain practice is now required for everyone, and rests the whole claim on a single verse.

- 1. Verify.** Open the verse. Does it exist where they say. Read the verse and the chapter around it. Check the Hebrew of the key word. Say the claim survives. The verse is real and roughly says what they cite.
- 2. Direction.** Does the practice move you toward the G-d of Israel and His Torah, or toward a teacher and a hidden knowledge. Say it is neutral on worship.
- 3. Add or subtract.** The teaching makes a new practice binding on everyone. That is an addition. Flag it.
- 4. Second witness.** Search the rest of Torah, the Prophets, the Writings. If nothing else establishes this obligation, you have one anchor and no support.
- 5. Verdict.** It contradicts no higher text, so it is not a rejection on direction. But it is a binding addition with no second witness. Set it aside. Do not adopt it.

A worked example from Korach

Numbers 16:3. Korach and his followers tell Moshe, You take too much upon yourself. The whole community, all of them, is holy, and HaShem is in their midst. Why do you raise yourself above the assembly of HaShem. This walks the same test Matti ran in the dvar on Parshat Korach, “Test Everything.” Find the full teaching at letsechad.com/teachings/parshat-korach once it posts.

1. **Verify.** Israel is holy (Exodus 19:6, Leviticus 19:2), and HaShem dwells among them (Exodus 25:8). Both true. What is left to test is the accusation itself, that Moshe and Aaron raised themselves above the assembly.
2. **Direction.** Deuteronomy 13. Korach is not calling the people to deeper service. He is calling them to reject the priesthood HaShem gave Aaron. The pull is away from the order HaShem established.
3. **Add or subtract.** Deuteronomy 4:2. HaShem drew a clear line between priests, Levites, and the rest of Israel, Numbers 3:10. Korach's claim erases that line and hands the priesthood to himself. Subtraction dressed up as equality.
4. **Second witness.** Deuteronomy 19:15. Search for anywhere else Scripture backs the claim that Moshe and Aaron exalted themselves. There is none. The Ten Commandments alone do not settle this one. Deuteronomy does. It is packed with HaShem appointing Moshe and Aaron directly.
5. **Verdict.** Reject. The claim survives verification and sounds reasonable standing alone. It fails the moment you reach Deuteronomy. Fourteen thousand seven hundred people died holding to it anyway (Numbers 17:14, numbered 16:49 in many English Bibles).

Discussion questions

1. Name a teaching you accepted without checking the source. What would the first phase have shown you.
2. Why does a true sign not make a teaching true. Where does Scripture say so.
3. What is the difference between a teaching you set aside and a teaching you reject. Why does the difference matter.
4. Where in your own walk have you added a command, or set one down, without testing it.
5. Which of the four selling tells have you seen in the space. How did you respond.
6. Take a real claim you have heard and run it through the whole method out loud. Where does it land.

Test everything against the word. Hold fast to what is established. One stick in His hand.